

A Guide to Buying the 'Perfect' Projector

Looking for a projector for the classroom, home theatre, meeting room, auditorium or even for gaming? Here's a guide that helps you decide between the huge variety of models, as well as a wide range of technologies, shapes and sizes.

Projectors are no longer used only in those stylish meeting rooms. People are now also replacing their huge LCD and plasma screens with these reflectors. And gone are the days when they were categorised based on their weight. Technology has changed all that! Saji Kumar, director, product management, Acer India, explains, "Earlier, we used to bundle projectors with other key products as there was not much demand for them. Now we see so many requirements for projectors coming from various segments that we have dedicated manpower for this product. It has become a key product like desktops and laptops." Apart from Acer, there are other brands like Hitachi that offer a variety of technologically advanced projectors. Tarun Jain, country head, Hitachi Home Electronics India, says, "Hitachi offers a comprehensive range of projectors, designed to suit varied space and projection needs. Whether it is maximising screen size in a small room, limiting shadowing and glare, or maximising image quality in a large space, we have a projector for every purpose."

Comparing DLP-based projectors with LCD versions

Projectors can be best described as inverted cameras which, instead of receiving light, emit it out of the lens. They fall into two broad categories, LCD- and DLP-based. LCDs represent an old technology and the first projector ever launched was a LCD version. With time, the use of DLP projectors has become more widespread. There are many leading players in the market including Acer, Hitachi and BenQ, and most of them offer DLP projectors. Saji Kumar states, "We focus on DLP projectors as it accounts for 60-65 per cent of the market." DLP or digital light processing projectors use a type of MEMS (microelectromechanical systems) technology with a digital micro-mirror device. These projectors are used in a variety of display applications, ranging from traditional static displays to interactive displays. They are also used in non-traditional applications like the security, medical and industrial domains.

Factors you should consider when buying a projector

Buying a projector is a major decision and there are many factors to keep in mind when doing so. Potential buyers should be very clear about what their requirements are and then thoroughly research what the market offers, as a projector is an expensive product to acquire. This is where companies shoulder a big portion of the responsibility of ensuring buyers pick up the right product. Says Jain, "We have deliberately introduced this product at an extremely

affordable price point, in order to get more people to indulge in their craving for bold, big-screen entertainment at home. Packed with an assortment of advanced features and Hitachi's unparalleled technology and reliability, our designers have ensured that this projector truly enhances the entertainment experience — presenting movies, sports and video games in a way that one has never seen before."

Acer believes in giving the best support to its customers. Kumar explains, "We first try and understand the requirements of our customer, as we just don't want to sell a product. Rather, we want to help a customer buy a product. We ask a few questions before selling our product—whether the customer is looking for a home theatre, what the room's dimensions are, the resolution or brightness required, etc."

To help you decide on what you need, here are a few factors to keep in mind.

Specifications: If you're a technical person, you will know the kind of specifications required for your projector. But if you are not, you will have to research a bit on that too. Specifications would include a few factors that are listed below.

Dimensions: The dimension of the room in which you plan to place your projector. Projectors have different configurations to suit the dimensions of a place.

Size: Projectors now have a wide range in shapes and sizes as well.

Wireless or wired: Both wireless and wired projectors are now available. If you are planning to buy one for your home, you may be comfortable with the wired version but if you're looking for a projector in your meeting room then a wireless projector might be more appropriate.

Resolution: This is the number of pixels used to display an image. If the projector has a higher resolution, it uses more pixels to create the image, which results in a cleaner, sharper and crisper image. A high resolution will be necessary if the projector is intended for classrooms or meeting rooms as it will help to project charts, texts and graphs more clearly.

Colour brightness or lumens: Select the level of brightness based on the room's dimensions. The brightness of a projector is measured in lumens. For homes, you would need nearly 1500 lumens, and for classrooms and conference rooms, you would need a minimum of 2500 lumens. For larger spaces like auditoriums, you would need even higher lumens.

Distance and positioning: This refers to the distance between the projector and the screen. The position of the projector and the dimensions of the room or hall will determine the size of the image projected. You would need to look for the features that offer flexibility in placement.